

The Green Mummy

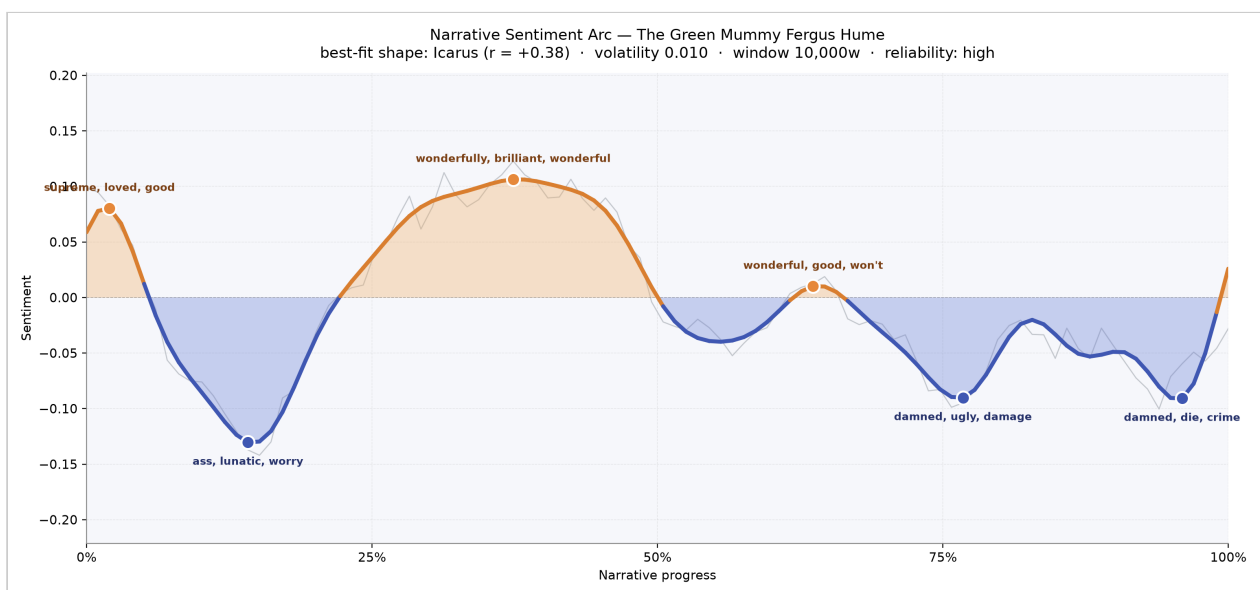
by Fergus Hume

88,822 words · an Icarus arc — flight in the first half, a long slow scorching descent through the second

The shape of the story

Hume's mystery opens in something like sunlight. The earliest pages glimmer with "supreme, loved, good, glad", the kind of soft domestic warmth that settles a reader into a chair. Then, almost at once, the floor drops. Roughly a seventh of the way in, the mood curdles into the book's first bruise — a valley thick with "ass, lunatic, worry, worried, furious, lost" — as if a household argument spilled onto the page and refused to be tidied. The story climbs out of that pit and reaches its brightest ridge near the one-third mark, brimming with "wonderfully, brilliant, wonderful, good, admires, love": courtship, praise, the giddy middle of an Edwardian romance where the puzzle still feels like a game.

After that peak, the arc behaves like a man who has flown too near his own cleverness. The second half is a long, uneven fall. A late-middle plateau still murmurs "wonderful, good, joy, beauty, glad", but the smoothing barely lifts above zero — hope grown thin. From there the descent hardens. Around the three-quarter mark the tone darkens into "damned, ugly, damage, angry, liar, madness", and by the final tenth the book closes in a hush of "damned, die, crime, worse, killed, dying". This is the Icarus signature — brightness earned, then spent — and Hume trusts it enough to leave the last page cool rather than triumphant. The line is smooth and its reliability is high; the descent is not a jitter, it is a considered burn.

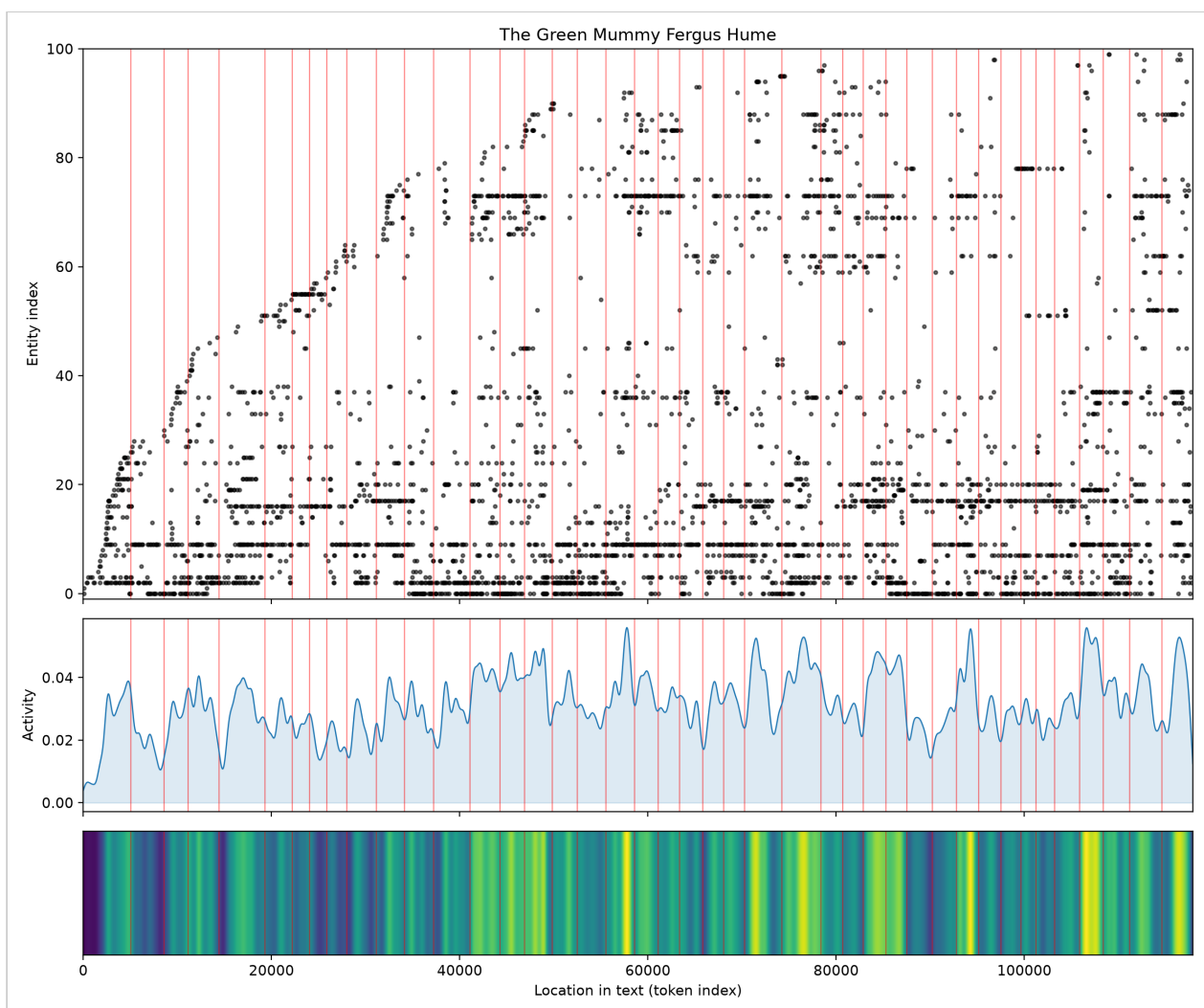


A bright climb to a brilliant middle, then a widening shadow toward the crime.

Who lives on the page

The novel's gravity centres on Professor Braddock, the mummy-hungry Egyptologist, whose name dominates the roll call with 434 mentions — his obsession is quite literally the book's most-spoken word. Circling him are Hope, the young lover, and Lucy, the daughter caught between father and suitor; between them the marriage plot breathes. Then comes the sinuous Hiram Jasher, the smuggler-adventurer whose 393 mentions make him nearly Braddock's equal in narrative weight — a rival gravity of appetite and cunning. Sir Random, Bolton, Frank, Sidney and the Peruvian nobleman Don Pedro de Gayangos, along with his daughter Donna Inez, fill out the ensemble.

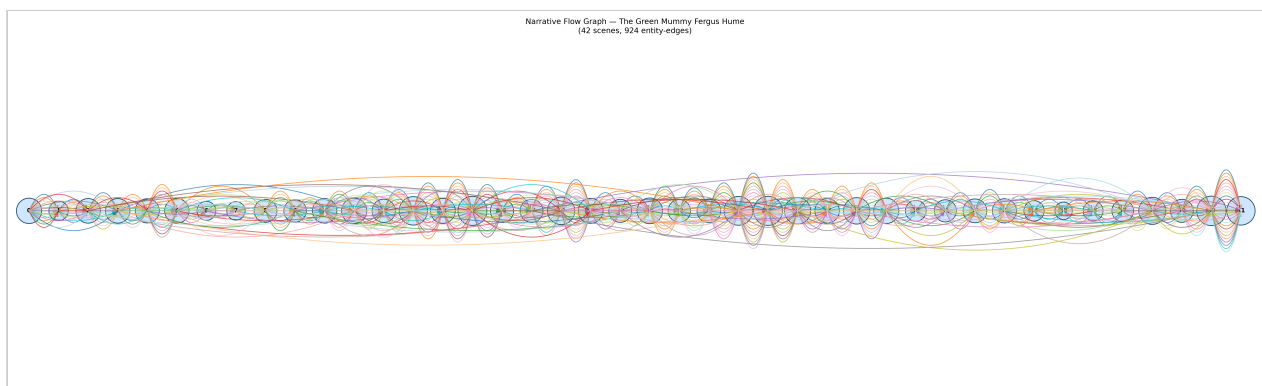
A few labels wobble at the edges. "Archie" is filed as an organisation and "Cockatoo" and "Hervey" drift into place-name territory, when in truth Cockatoo is Don Pedro's Kanaka servant and Hervey a ship's captain — small misreadings by the tagger, not by the book. The word "mummy" itself sits in the character list at fifty-nine mentions, which is exactly right: the corpse of Inca Caxas is treated as a personage, spoken to and about, coveted like a lover.



Presences accumulating steadily through the first third, then a busy, populated middle and end.

The weave of scenes

Across forty-two scenes and nearly a thousand connecting threads, the narrative reads like a wide, gently swelling river with two brighter eddies at either bank. Early chapters carry mid-sized casts of twenty-odd figures — enough to sketch a village, not enough to crowd it. The middle stretches (scenes fourteen through twenty-six) fatten to thirty-six, thirty-seven, thirty-eight presences per scene as suspects, servants, sailors and travellers pour in around the stolen mummy. A quieter passage follows near the three-quarter mark, where scenes thirty-five and thirty-six drop to fifteen and nine — an intimate hush before the reveal. Then the finale swells again to thirty-nine and thirty-six: the parlour scene, the confession, the ring of witnesses. The braid is classic detective architecture — introduce, entangle, isolate, gather, resolve — and Hume plays it with a craftsman's confidence.



A long chain of overlapping loops — the ensemble knot of a proper drawing-room mystery.

What a reader takes away

The Green Mummy leaves the taste of a warm evening that cooled slowly into something graver. Hume gives you flirtation, fussy scholarship and a green-wrapped corpse, then lets greed do its patient work until the book's last breath is spent on crime and dying. You close it not shaken but sobered — reminded that curiosity, when it forgets its manners, can bury more than it unearths.